

Aru va'en

A Keeping of the Troth

Before throne and pasture, before fang and fleece, there was the Troth.

Before the Troth had a name, it had an ache.

The First Keeping: Night

Cries in the dark.

At first I thought they were wolves.

Then I thought they were children.

Then I understood that some cries are older than names. They come up from the torn places of the world, from fields where blood has entered the soil, from mouths that no longer know whether they are praying or dying.

They came before dawn because before dawn is when the forest listens.

The dens grew restless. Mothers drew their young closer. Old wolves lifted their heads but did not rise. Even the blind ones opened their eyes toward the border, toward that thin place where the trees ended and the mist began.

I was young then, though not as young as I wanted to be.

I am Vaelun.

A scout of the outer ring. A watcher of the boundary stones. One of those who keeps to the places where our scent thins and other things begin.

But Vaelun named more than scouts.

It named all those the Troth had set at a threshold — of flesh, of grief, of the world's torn places.

Vaelun.

Brother, watcher, coal-under-ash.

So the Gravane remembered us into our names.

But among the Vaelun I bore another name.

Vaerun.

Not a keeping of the threshold.

An office of the crossing.

The one set at the veil.

The one bound to cross.

There was little majesty in the office. Mostly it was mud, hunger, cold, and listening.

Still, the office mattered.

An office names before it commands.

And what it names, it binds.

Bindings that are older than choice.

Names that are older than the ones who bore them.

Then the cries came again.

They moved through the forest like waves of nausea. The air tasted of acid and copper. Somewhere beyond the veil, something living dragged itself across leaves. Something wounded called out and was answered by something worse.

I did not want to go.

This is the first truth.

Not that I went bravely.

Not that I was eager.

Not that fear vanished when the Hrovan summoned me.

Fear was not my shame.

Only later did I learn that fear is often the last mercy given to the soul.

The danger was not that I feared.

The danger was that fear could change its face.

I was afraid when I entered his hall. I was trembling when I bowed. I froze when he looked down from the stone seat where generations had sat, his muzzle silvered, his eyes dark with old knowledge.

The Hrovan sat beneath the torn banners.

Not only king.

Hrovan was older than crown, older than throne, older than the right to command.

It meant the one who bears the hall.

The one beneath whose burden the people remember they are one body.

We called him lord because that was easier.

But when the Gravane spoke of him, they said Hrovan, and lowered their heads.

He needed no crown.

The stone seat, the torn banners, and the silence of the gathered wolves were crown enough.

"Vaerun, you have heard them," he said.

"Yes, my lord."

"And you know from where they come."

I did not answer.

The Hrovan rose and looked away.

Behind him hung the old banners, torn by wars I had been taught to remember but could not imagine. Beneath them were the names of wolves who had gone beyond the veil and not returned. I had touched those names as a cub. I had thought them beautiful.

Now they looked like teeth.

Among them I recognized something I had not seen before: that many of those names bore the old office, Vaerun, before they bore anything else. The veil first. The stone seat after, if at all.

He turned, and I held my breath.

"Go," commanded the Hrovan. "Seek out that which cries."

So I went.

The Second Keeping: Pre-Dawn

The borderlands belonged neither to night nor morning.

They were the color of ash before fire. The grass there grew low and silver. The trees leaned away from one another as though ashamed. Stones marked the old boundary line, half-buried now, their faces furred with moss.

Beyond them was the pasture-world.

We had never held fellowship with the sheep.

That should be said.

We mocked their softness. We laughed at their terror. We called them foolish because they ran when shadows moved and huddled when thunder spoke.

Sometimes, in older days, before the Troth was remembered, our fathers had hunted them.

But the bond was older than I was.

Older than the Hrovan.

Older than any name we had carried for it.

I came to the last place of the veil, where the trees thinned and the mist lay low against the stones.

There I found a lamb.

Or the first face of one.

It stood alone beneath a blackthorn tree, one eye clouded white, the other wide and wet with terror. Its wool was clotted with burrs and blood. Flies moved along its mouth. When it heard me, it tried to run, but its legs folded beneath it, and from its throat came the cry I had heard in the forest.

Not a bleat.

Not speech.

A breaking.

I did not yet cross.

For a moment I stood with one paw still in the forest and one near the stones.

Behind me were the dens, the mothers, the torn banners, the Hrovan.

Before me, the veil did not hide what lay beyond it.

It only made crossing a different thing than seeing.

The pasture-world did not begin.

It failed.

The flock wandered in circles beyond the veil. Some were fevered. Some had bitten themselves raw. Some pressed their heads against stones until the skull cracked. Lambs searched for mothers who no longer knew them. Ewes gave milk darkened by rot.

And behind the flock came the diseased.

I had no name for them then.

They had once been beasts, I think.

Some had the shape of wolves. Some had the shape of sheep. Some had the shape of neither.

Their hides hung loose.

Their mouths foamed.

Their eyes shone with a light that had curdled.

I crossed the stones.

The twilight deepened.

I followed the cries to a hill silhouetted against a red predawn sky.

There I saw him.

The Shepherd stood alone.

His robe was torn. One sleeve hung dark with blood. Around his feet the ground had been trampled into mud. The diseased circled below him, climbing, falling, rising again.

His wounds were old. Older than the night, older than the host below him. I could not say how I knew this. Only that they had not been given here.

In his arms he carried a lamb.

Small.

White beneath the blood.

Still alive.

The Shepherd did not flee.

This angered me.

I did not understand why.

Perhaps because he looked weak. Perhaps because he looked as if he had been waiting. Perhaps because something in me wanted him to save them as lords save: by command, by terror, by force.

But he only stood there.

Holding the lamb.

He said nothing.

His face did not command.

It did not pity from above.

It did not explain why he remained.

And that troubled me more than if he had spoken.

Then I returned to the Hrovan.

"My lord," I said, "that which cries is not outside the Troth."

The hall was silent.

The old wolves watched me from the shadows.

I told him of the flock. I told him of the disease. I told him of the hill, the red sky, the lamb in the Shepherd's arms, the host gathering below.

When I had finished, I asked for the answer I did not want to hear.

"What would you have me do, Lord?"

The Hrovan closed his eyes.

For a long time he did not move.

Then he said, "You know the bond, Vaerun."

I did.

That was the wound of it.

He opened his eyes.

"When the cry enters the Troth..."

I finished the old words because they were older than my knowing of them.

"...no wolf may look away."

The floor fell away beneath me.

"My lord."

"My son."

I hated him then, a little.

Not because he was cruel.

Because he was not.

Cruelty would have been easier to bear.

No one else would hear what came next.

The old wolves had gone still in the shadows. It was only us.

"Before throne and pasture," said the Hrovan, "before fang and fleece, there was the Troth."

Not as ceremony. Not for the hall.

For me.

The Troth was not taught to me as a cub.

It was recognized in me. Not in words, but in silence — in the way old wolves lowered their heads when the Shepherd's name was spoken.

The Troth was not a story.

Stories end.

The Troth remains.

I knew what it would ask of me.

And I feared it.

The Hrovan came down from the stone seat and placed his forehead against mine.

His breath smelled of winter.

"Summon those who have not been released," he said.

He did not say Truvane.

He did not need to.

Then he lifted his head.

At first I thought he was answering the cries beyond the veil.

Then I understood.

He was carrying them.

The sound that came from him was not command only, and not grief only. It began with the lamb's cry, thin and broken, taken into the deep chamber of a wolf's chest.

Then it changed. It widened. It became older than mourning, older than warning, older than speech.

The howl passed through the hall.

The torn banners stirred though no wind entered.

The old wolves lowered their heads.

Beyond the stone hollow, other throats took it up: first the watchers, then the mothers, then the blind ones, then the cubs who did not yet know why they trembled.

The howl that had heard the cry echoed through the land.

It moved through the forest as the cry had moved through it before dawn.

But this was not the cry.

This was the cry remembered by wolves.

This was the cry heard.

By the time it reached the boundary stones, every den had heard it. Every scar had heard it. Every wolf still within the Troth's keeping had heard itself named.

The Truvane would come.

I lowered my head.

And I feared.

The Third Keeping: The Calling of the Truvane

Before we ran toward the hill, the Truvane came.

They came because the howl had passed over the dens and left no faithful thing untouched.

They came beneath the torn banners in the hollow of stone, where the first vows had been spoken before any living wolf had a name: mothers, cubs, watchers, singers, scarred ones, lame ones, blind ones, old wolves whose legs shook beneath their own weight.

No fire was lit.

No feast was prepared.

No drum was struck.

The Truvane did not come to celebrate.

They came to listen.

I stood before them with my head lowered.

The Hrovan stood behind me.

Then the Gravane came out from the shadows.

Not elders only.

Scar-bearers.

Rememberers.

Those whose keeping had been written upon them.

The ones old enough to know that no holy thing passes through flesh without leaving a mark.

When they entered the hollow, every wolf became still.

For the Gravane remembered the four curses.

The fang turned inward.

The eye sealed shut.

The paw washed clean of blood.

The mouth closed around the cry.

They had pressed their signs into us when we were young.

Not as stories.

As warnings.

Their signs did not appear only upon the fallen.

That was the first terror.

The curses could be cast upon the faithful.

They could make a brother look like what he feared becoming.

Not enough to know.

Only enough for the eye to flinch.

That was why the Gravane pressed the signs into us young.

Not so we could cast them back.

So we could name what was happening to us before it finished happening.

Then the eldest of the Gravane — blind, and the oldest among them — lifted her head and spoke in the old tongue.

"Ur va. Thar un. Veth ara."

The hollow answered:

"Aru va'en."

The words were older than speech as I knew it. I understood them as cubs understand thunder: not by meaning, but by trembling.

The eldest walked among us slowly.

Not choosing.

Listening for the Troth.

She paused before a young wolf whose shoulders were thick with strength. He lifted his head too quickly. His eyes were bright. He wanted to be called.

The Gravane passed him by.

Then she came to Harrow, whose left ear had been torn away by a boar.

Harrow did not lift his head.

He shook.

Not much.

Only enough.

The Gravane touched her brow to his.

"Harrow."

The Truvane answered:

"Aru va'en."

So the first was called.

Sable was called next, singing under his breath because silence frightened him.

"Do not hide the song," said the Gravane.

Sable lowered himself to the ground.

"Sable."

"Aru va'en."

So the second was called.

Then Old Murn.

A murmur passed through the hollow.

Murn should not have been chosen. His bones were old. His breath was rough. One winter had nearly taken him already, and the next was waiting.

He grinned when the blind Gravane faced him.

"I wondered when you would find me," he said.

The Gravane struck him lightly across the muzzle.

"You were never hidden."

"Murn."

"Aru va'en."

So the third was called.

The fourth calling fell upon Little Vey.

He was not little anymore.

But names given in cubhood are not easily taken back, and his had gone deeper than size.

Vey was an old word.

It had meant small. Then ember. Then the last light under ash.

Among the Vaelun, we used the name gently.

The Gravane did not.

When they spoke it, they lowered their heads.

Little Vey stood beside me, trying not to tremble and failing.

When the Gravane came near, he looked first to me.

Not to the Hrovan.

Not to the banners.

To me.

"Vaerun," he whispered.

The word seemed too large in his mouth.

Or perhaps he was the only one among us small enough to carry it rightly.

The Gravane heard him.

"That is why," she said.

Then she touched his brow.

"Vey."

"Aru va'en."

So the fourth was called.

Then the others were named.

Brindle, broad-backed and gentle, who had once carried a starving cub three days through snow and never spoken of it.

Keld, hard of jaw and slow to anger, whose silence did not hide emptiness but depth.

Ash, pale as winter grass, who feared blood and came anyway.

Rook, black-pawed and sharp-eyed, who saw movements at the edge of things before others thought to look.

Yarrow, wound-licker and herb-finder, whose mercy had never been clean.

Thorn, fierce and narrow, who had spent his life learning where anger ended and guardianship began.

Ostra, scarred across the ribs, who had lost three brothers beyond the veil and still came when the cries began.

Fen, mud-colored and quiet, who knew how to stand in sinking ground.

After each name, the Truvane answered:

"Aru va'en."

And with each answer, the hollow grew heavier.

Not with glory.

With recognition.

These were not the fearless.

These were not the pure.

These were not the ones who could bear the Troth without wound.

They were the ones whose fear had not yet turned its fang inward.

The ones whose eyes had not sealed shut.

The ones whose paws were willing to be stained.

The ones whose mouths had not closed around the cry.

When the twelfth had been named, the Gravane turned to me.

I waited for the old words.

None came.

The Hrovan placed his muzzle near my ear.

"You were called before you entered the hollow," he said.

Twelve beside me.

Twelve Vaelun.

Twelve witnessed by the Truvane, named by the Gravane as they listened for the Troth, not because they were unafraid, but because their fear still knew how to bow.

The Gravane lowered their heads.

The Truvane lowered theirs.

The Hrovan spoke last.

"Before throne and pasture," he said, "before fang and fleece, there was the Troth."

And all who remembered answered:

"The Troth remains."

Then the Hrovan came to us.

He did not stand above us.

He stood among us.

His eyes passed over Harrow, Sable, Murn, Little Vey, Brindle, Keld, Ash, Rook, Yarrow, Thorn, Ostra, Fen.

Last, they came to me.

"Vaerun," he said, "do not go because you are unafraid."

No one moved.

No cub cried.

No old wolf breathed loudly.

His eyes had gone to the old names beneath the banners.

"Fear remembers the shape of the soul."

Then Little Vey stepped close behind me.

"Vaerun," he whispered.

The word crossed the hollow like a cord thrown through darkness.

And because he called me Vaerun, I remembered that I was bound.

So we went.

The Fourth Keeping: Eternal Dawn

We ran toward the hill in twilight.

Twelve beside me.

Twelve Vaelun.

No one spoke after we crossed the stones.

The veil closed behind us without sound.

The twilight did not become dawn.

It became exposure.

The White Moon still hung at the edge of the world, thin and stricken, not yet gone from the sky.

Then the Black Sun rose against it.

It came without morning.

One moment we were moving through the last gray of the borderlands. The next, every wound was visible. Every tooth. Every fly. Every smear of blood drying black in the wool of the lambs.

Black light from the east.

Pale retreat in the west.

And between the two, the sky opened like an old wound torn anew.

The Black Sun did not warm the world.

It opened it.

Every scent rose naked beneath it: blood in wool, fear in milk, fever under the skin, rot sweetening at the edges of wounds, old dung, wet iron, trampled grass, the rank breath of things that had forgotten what they were.

Nothing could hide its smell.

Not the lamb.

Not the host.

Not us.

The hill stood before us as if it had been waiting inside the wound all along.

The Shepherd saw us coming.

He did not smile.

He did not thank us.

He looked at us as one looks at rain after drought: with grief and recognition.

Behind him, the White Moon sank lower.

Above him, the Black Sun climbed.

No true dawn came between them.

Only a dawn that would not become morning.

Only the long, merciless unveiling of what had been hidden by night.

We formed the circle around him.

The lamb cried once.

Then the diseased came.

They broke upon the hill like weather.

The first struck Harrow and opened his shoulder to the bone. The second leapt at the Shepherd, and I caught it in my jaws. Its blood burned my tongue. It tasted of iron left too long in water.

We held.

At first, holding had a shape.

Shoulder beside shoulder.

Paw beside paw.

The host before us.

At the center, the Shepherd stood with the lamb in his arms.

That was the first mercy.

To know where to stand.

To know what must not be yielded.

The Shepherd said nothing.

His face did not command us.

It did not pity us from above.

He remained at the center.

So we held again.

But the second holding was harder.

Claws entered us.

Teeth found us.

Fever passed through bites and torn skin.

The diseased screamed with voices that sounded almost like ours. Their breath came hot and wrong. Their hides stank of wet graves, spoiled milk, and old fear gone rancid.

Some had the shoulders of wolves, but their eyes were empty of brotherhood — not blind, but turned so far inward that nothing outside them registered as kin.

Some had the faces of sheep, but no innocence remained in them. What remained was innocence's hollow: the wide eye that did not see, the soft mouth that did not feel, the stillness of a thing that had forgotten it was ever afraid.

Some were neither wolf nor sheep, but shadows given hunger, or pale shapes of light moving wrongly through the grass. These were not hungry only. Hunger has mercy in it. Hunger ends when fed. These things wanted ruin — not the ruin of flesh, but of the name inside the flesh. They wanted to make you forget what you had been before they found you.

Then the fallen came among them.

Not apart from the host.

Not leading it.

Within it.

The fallen did not reveal themselves by their own deformity.

That would have been mercy.

They came wearing voices we loved.

A brother's laugh, almost right.

A mother's call, almost tender.

The face of a dead companion, held a little too long, as though something behind it had learned the shape but not the sorrow.

And beneath each likeness was a wrongness of scent.

Not enough to name.

Only enough to trouble the blood.

Harrow's laugh came from a mouth that did not smell of Harrow.

Sable's song came from a throat without Sable's fear in it.

Little Vey's face appeared in the host, but without the small warm scent of ash and rain that belonged to him.

One wore my own eyes and smelled of a den I had never entered.

Each likeness was wrong by less than sight could name.

Not enough to believe.

Only enough for the blood to hesitate.

The fallen did not show us what they were.

They accused us of already being what we feared.

One called out in Harrow's laugh while Harrow bled beside me, and for a heartbeat I saw Harrow's own fang bent inward toward his throat.

One cried in Sable's voice, and Sable's mouth seemed sewn around the song he would not sing.

One wore Little Vey's face, almost truly, almost tenderly, and the ground beneath Vey's paws looked white and clean, as if no blood had ever touched him.

One looked at me with my own eyes.

I felt Harrow's fang against his own throat before I knew I was seeing it.

I heard Sable's silence where his song had been.

I felt the cleanness of a paw that had never been stained, and wanted it.

I felt my own mouth beginning to close.

The four curses passed over us like shadows over water.

So we held a third time.

Not because we were certain.

Because we were afraid.

Fear remembered the shape of the soul when sight forgot it.

By the first hour, Sable no longer sang.

By the next, Harrow was dead.

Or perhaps it was midnight.

Or dawn.

Under the Black Sun, such things had no meaning.

We dragged Harrow's body inward so the host could not take him.

The Shepherd stood above us with the lamb in his arms.

Still he did not flee.

Still the lamb breathed.

Under that light, I no longer knew whether the lamb before us was the first lamb, the last lamb, or every lamb that had ever cried out from the torn places of the world.

It was one and many.

Near enough to smell.

Vast enough to break the heart.

So we held beyond counting.

The Black Sun did not move.

It hung above the hill like an eye that had forgotten how to close.

Under it, time broke.

The grass died and grew and died again.

Snow fell once, but did not cool us.

Rain came and washed nothing clean.

The flock changed.

Lambs became sheep.

Sheep became bones.

Bones sank into earth.

New lambs cried where the old had fallen.

Still the Shepherd stood.

Still the host climbed.

Still the circle closed where it had been opened.

This is what I remember of each of them.

Harrow held by refusing to yield.

Sable held by singing until song was taken from him.

Murn held by laughing at terror until terror forgot its own name.

Brindle held by making his body a door no ruin could pass.

Keld held in silence, and his silence became a wall.

Ash held while trembling at every opened wound.

Rook held by seeing the strike before it came.

Yarrow held by pressing his own torn body against wounds he could not heal.

Thorn held by turning anger back into guardianship again and again.

Ostra held with the grief of three brothers already behind her.

Fen held as sinking ground holds roots.

And Little Vey held because he was little enough to stand where greater things could not.

Murn died in winter, though there were no winters anymore.

He died laughing, not because anything was funny, but because a diseased thing had tried to frighten him by wearing his own young face.

"I was uglier than that," he said.

Then he fell, and the circle closed over the place where he had stood.

Harrow was gone.

Murn was gone.

Sable's song had been taken from him.

The circle was smaller now.

And yet it did not shrink.

That was when I looked back toward the center.

The Shepherd had not moved away from us.

He had not risen above the ruin.

The grief of the hill had entered him, and still his hands held the lamb.

It did not close him.

It did not make him cruel.

It did not make him clean.

It passed through him and returned to us changed.

Not as command.

Not as courage.

As room.

Where Harrow had fallen, Brindle stood wider without growing larger.

Where Murn had laughed and died, Keld's silence deepened until it covered more ground than any body should.

Where Sable's song had been taken, Ash trembled and held the empty place beside him.

The circle closed where it had been opened.

Not because we became greater.

Because the Shepherd's grief moved through us, shoulder to shoulder, wound to wound, making the small able to bear what was too large.

After that, holding no longer had a shape.

It had a smell.

Blood.

Mud.

Burned wool.

Rot.

Cold iron.

The Shepherd's robe stiff with old wounds.

The lamb's frightened milk-breath.

The sharp animal reek of my own fear.

The ash-and-rain scent of Little Vey somewhere at my back.

Little Vey lasted longer than any of us expected.

He lost an eye, then a foreleg, then most of one ear.

He learned to fight from the ground.

When he could no longer stand, he bit at the ankles of anything that crossed the line.

Once, when the host drew back, he asked me, "Do you think the Hrovan remembers us?"

I looked toward the veil.

There was no forest anymore.

Only light.

Only hill.

Only the crying of the lamb.

"Yes," I said.

It was not an answer.

It was a duty.

At times I could no longer tell whether the blood in my mouth was mine or another's. Disease moved through me in waves. My dreams grew teeth. I heard my brothers calling from beneath the ground.

Fear remained.

Not as an enemy.

Not as something to defeat.

It became the weight of my own body.

The ache in the ribs.

The shaking before the next assault.

The smell of myself becoming something I did not want to know.

Then came the wish.

Small.

Shameful.

Merciful, it almost seemed.

That the lamb would stop crying.

Only that.

Not that it should die.

Not that I wished it harm.

Only that the sound would end, and with it the tearing inside me.

Then something in the host lifted its head, as though my stillness had changed the air.

A shape rose from the bodies below. It wore no face I knew, and yet I knew it. Its mouth was closed too gently, as if silence had become a kindness.

It looked at me, and for a heartbeat my own jaws felt sealed around the cry.

Not biting.

Closing.

I could not hear the lamb.

Worse.

I could not smell it.

No wool.

No milk.

No blood.

No small frightened life held against the Shepherd's robe.

The world had become clean.

That was when terror saved me.

I began to fall.

Not down.

Inward.

Into the place where silence waited as a den waits: still, warm, and without cry.

Then I remembered his face.

No.

It remembered me.

The Shepherd's grief, written upon my heart before I knew I would need it, rose out of the dark within me. Slowly, through fever, blood, and the shrieking host, his face emerged.

Not commanding.

Not accusing.

Grieving.

Steady.

His grief bound the circle.

Then I felt Little Vey at my back.

I knew him by more than sound.

The drag of one ruined paw.

The wet pull of breath through broken teeth.

The small voice, thinner now, still finding the office I had almost lost.

And his scent.

Ash under rain.

Blood gone cold.

The last warmth of a coal no wind could kill.

"Vaerun."

Again.

"Vaerun."

I could not turn to see him.

The circle would not allow it.

So I held with Vey at my back.

I heard the lamb again.

So I held.

Then I heard only the host.

Only the lamb.

Only the Black Sun pressing its silence into the world.

I knew then that Little Vey had gone where I could not follow.

And still, where he had stood, my back did not feel empty.

The circle had lost its shape.

And yet the circle held.

Not around emptiness.

Around the Shepherd.

Around the lamb.

Around the cry that had entered the Troth.

Then I understood what I had not been able to understand while Vey still breathed at my back.

The circle was not made by number.

It was made by keeping.

Little Vey was gone.

And still he held.

Harrow was gone.

Murn was gone.

The others were gone or going.

And still they held.

Then I heard the lamb again.

One cry.

Then many.

Near enough to smell.

Vast enough to break the heart.

And as one, and as many, I held.

So I tore until my forelegs trembled.

I bit until I could not feel my jaw.

When I could not run, I walked.

When I could not walk, I limped.

When I could not limp, I crawled.

When crawling failed me, I dragged myself forward by tooth and claw.

And when rising was no longer possible,

I rose again.

The Fifth Keeping: Mourn

At last I did not rise.

The ground received me. That was how I knew.

For ages the ground had been stone, mud, ash, bone beneath us. Now it opened like a hand. My body had become very heavy. My breath entered me with difficulty and left without regret.

Around me the circle was gone.

Or perhaps I could no longer see it.

The Black Sun dimmed.

The host drew back.

The cries receded until they sounded like water heard from inside sleep.

Someone came near.

I smelled wool.

A lamb was placed gently between my jaws.

Not as prey.

Not as food.

As mothers carry their young.

As the living bear the helpless.

My mouth, which had been made terrible by war, became for a moment a cradle.

I wanted to say that I could not carry it.

I wanted to say I was finished.

But the lamb was warm.

The Troth in me remembered.

So I closed my teeth carefully around nothing but wool, and with the last strength left in me, I bore it forward.

One step.

Then none.

Darkness received me.

And there, where no brother could follow and no voice could answer for me, I was given a thing I have never spoken of except in the old telling.

Not because it was secret.

Because it was too large to survive ordinary speech.

I do not know whether my brothers saw this.

I do not think they did.

Some visions are not given to the worthy.

They are given to the one nearest breaking, because only the breaking place is wide enough for them to enter.

I saw the hollow of stone beneath the torn banners, though no roof stood over it and no walls enclosed it.

I saw the stone seat.

Empty.

Not empty.

Behind it lay a wolf vast enough to shelter the hollow as mountains shelter a valley.

It did not crouch to spring.

It did not open its jaws to devour.

Its body was made of scars.

Ancient scars from wounds no living wolf had seen given, yet every living wolf had inherited.

Aruvan.

The long wolf made by keeping.

Not by conquest.

Not by hunger.

By bearing what could not be passed aside.

Each Hrovan had added to it.

And many Hrovan had first been Vaerun, for the one set at the veil learns what the stone seat cannot teach: that command is not holy unless it has first trembled before the cry.

I saw the Hrovan I had known within that great scarred body, and behind him others, and behind them others still.

Each wounded.

Each larger than himself.

None alone.

I thought the Aruvan was the largest thing I would ever see.

Then it lowered its head.

Not to me.

To what was before it.

And there, where the Aruvan bowed, I saw the Shepherd.

A man.

Wounded.

Breathing.

His robe torn.

His arms marked by the weight of what he had carried.

He had received the grief of the world into himself.

But grief had not consumed him.

It moved through him as water moves through stone, cutting, healing, remembering the shape of every wound.

The Aruvan was vast.

But he held it.

Not by force.

Not by command.

By remaining.

I remembered then what the Hrovan had spoken beneath the torn banners.

Before throne and pasture.

Before fang and fleece.

There was—

But the word did not come.

The vision loosened.

The hollow drew away.

The torn banners folded into darkness.

The Aruvan became breath, warmth, something vast passing behind the world.

I tried to hold it.

I could not.

Someone was calling me back.

Not loudly.

Not by command.

By morning.

The hill vanished.

The blood vanished.

The Black Sun went out.

When I opened my eyes, spring morning had come.

The first thing I saw was grass.

Not the bitter grass of the borderlands, not the trampled mud beneath the hill, but grass washed in light. Each blade held a brightness of its own. The air was warm. Somewhere water moved over stones.

My brothers were there.

Not as they had been beneath the Black Sun.

Not ruined.

Not whole.

Themselves.

Harrow's ear was still torn, but the torn place shone faintly in the morning.

Murn still grinned, though nothing was funny, and his young face had come back to him and fit.

Sable was singing under his breath, and I understood that even his song had changed. It was not the song he had carried into battle. It had passed through the endless dawn and come back bearing marks of its own.

Brindle's back was bent, but light rested there.

Keld's jaw was scarred, but no bitterness held it closed.

Ash's paws were stained, and the stains shone.

Rook's eyes carried darkness at their edges, but they saw clearly.

Yarrow's mouth bore the taste of wounds, but no wound ruled him.

Thorn's anger had become stillness.

Ostra stood with three shadows behind her, and none of them were empty.

Fen was mud-colored still, and beneath him the grass grew deep.

Each scar remained.

Not as injury.

As witness.

The Black Sun had not been denied.

It had been borne.

We were not what we had been before the hill.

We were not what the host had tried to make of us.

We were what remained after the Troth had passed through flesh.

I looked for Little Vey.

He was there.

Not as the others were there — not with wounds that shone or scars that bore witness. He was there as an ember is there in ash: without shape, without edge, present in the warmth rather than the light.

I knew him by the smell of rain.

Then I looked down and saw my own side opened by a scar I did not remember receiving.

It ran from rib to shoulder, pale as dawn.

I touched it with my tongue and tasted no blood.

Only morning.

Then I saw the Shepherd.

He stood beneath a tree whose leaves moved though there was no wind.

The lamb walked toward him.

No blood marked it now.

No wound.

No trembling.

It crossed the grass with the solemnity of something newly born and ancient at once.

The Shepherd knelt.

He opened his arms.

The lamb entered them.

The Shepherd looked at me.

In his face was Night.

And Twilight.

And the long, unwaking dawn of the Black Sun.

And morning.

Nothing had been unseen.

Nothing had been wasted.

The Hrovan was there also, though I had not seen him arrive.

He stood at the edge of the meadow, silver muzzle lifted, eyes wet and proud.

I saw his scars truly for the first time.

Old ones.

Deep ones.

Scars from wounds I had never seen him suffer, from keepings I had never known him to have made.

And behind him — not as shadows, not as vision, but as the way one stone rests upon another in a wall that has stood longer than memory — stood others. Hrovane before him. Gravane before them. Each marked. Each having grown past the shape of a single life. Each having kept what could not be passed aside.

I had seen their shape in the dark, in the body of the Aruvan.

Now I saw their scars in morning light.

I went to bow, but my legs failed me, and he came instead to me.

"My son," he said.

That was all.

It was enough.

The Shepherd rose with the lamb in his arms.

The cries were gone.

No.

Not gone.

Answered.

He stood beneath the tree whose leaves moved though there was no wind, and I saw then that his grief had not ended because morning had come.

It had become morning.

Not by forgetting night.

Not by closing the wound.

By carrying it until life could pass through it again.

The lamb rested against him.

His hands held it carefully.

Human hands.

Scarred hands.

Hands that had touched wool, blood, mud, sickness, and still opened.

Then, on the breeze behind me, where Little Vey had stood and no longer stood, I heard a voice barely larger than breath.

"Vaerun."

I did not turn.

Some things leave no scent. Only an ache where the knowing was.

The voice came again, smaller than a flame under ash.

"Before the Troth," whispered Little Vey, "there was the Shepherd."

Before the vow was the cry.

Before grief was love.

We do not keep alone.

Pronunciation Guide

Aru va'en AH-ROO VAH-EN

A keeping of the troth; the response of the faithful at the calling

Vaelun VAY-LOON

Threshold-keepers; those set at the border between worlds

Vaerun VAY-ROON

The office of crossing; the one bound to pass the veil

Hrovan HROH-VAHN

The one who bears the hall; the lord who carries the people as a burden

Hrovane HROH-VAH-NEH

The ancestral line of Hrovans; those who held the hall before

Gravane GRAH-VAH-NEH

Scar-bearers and rememberers; those who carry and press the old signs

Truvane TROO-VAH-NEH

The gathered faithful; those who have not been released from the Troth

Aruvan AH-ROO-VAHN

The long wolf made by keeping; the body of the faithful across all ages

Vey VAY

An old word: small, then ember, then the last light under ash

Ur va. Thar un. Veth ara. OOR VAH · THAHR OON · VETH AH-RAH

The old tongue of the calling; literal meaning lost, understood by trembling